

Report Part Title: RESISTANCE AFTER THE WAR

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II. RESISTANCE AFTER THE WAR

A. A NEW MILITARY EQUATION

In the months following the war, many observers and political actors disagreed over how badly Hizbollah's military arsenal had suffered.¹¹¹ That question has lost much relevance. There is now virtual unanimity that Hizbollah has replenished its stocks. By asserting that the movement has strengthened its military capacity and possesses at least 20,000 rockets, Nasrallah implicitly gave credence to the claims by the UN, Israel and others that weapons had been transferred via the Syrian-Lebanese border in violation of Resolution 1701.¹¹² The Lebanese army also has intercepted weapons shipments allegedly for Hizbollah.

Although strengthened in hardware, Hizbollah finds itself on more difficult strategic terrain. Its self-proclaimed "divine victory" notwithstanding, the war complicated its military posture. In the South, it has lost the impressive network of bunkers and fortified positions it had patiently built since 2000.¹¹³ It also is deprived of much of its margin

¹¹¹ It is difficult to quantify the damage suffered by Hizbollah. According to the movement, around 200 of its fighters were killed, Crisis Group interview, Mahmud Qumati, 3 February 2007, but the real figure is probably slightly higher. In its latest report, Human Rights Watch assessed that 250 Hizbollah fighters were killed, http://hrw.org/reports/2007/lebanon0907/10.htm#_Toc175028505. The various categories involved (reservists, professionals and armed villagers) make any precise assessment all the more complex. According to some military analysts, Israeli attacks destroyed a significant portion of Hizbollah's military infrastructure, including bunkers adjoining the border and long-range missiles. See Anthony Cordesman, "Preliminary Lessons of the Israeli-Hizbollah War", Center for Strategic and International Studies, 17 August 2006, www.csis.org/media/csis/pubs/060817_isr_hez_lessons.pdf.

¹¹² Hassan Nasrallah speech commemorating the "divine victory", 22 September 2006, Al-Manar television. In a 23 July interview on Al Jazeera, he claimed Hizbollah now possessed an arsenal of rockets that could reach any corner of Israel, including Tel Aviv. See also "Report of the Secretary-General on the Implementation of Security Council Resolution 1701 (2006)", UNSC S/2007/392, 28 June 2007. The head of the defence ministry's political-security department, Amos Gilad, told Israel Radio that Syria continues to be a transit point for Iranian weapons and money to Hizbollah. "Syria ... is allowing the Iranians, and is itself arming Hizbollah in a massive fashion", Haaretz, 30 June 2006. The most significant weapons seizure occurred on 8 February 2007, when Hizbollah acknowledged that it owned a truck full of ammunition that was intercepted in an East Beirut suburb. A security official later said twenty Grad rockets and twenty rocket launchers were concealed in bags of straw, Associated Press, 8 February 2007.

¹¹³ Crisis Group interview, Timor Goksel, former UNIFIL spokesman, Beirut, 16 August 2007. A UNIFIL officer confirmed

of manoeuvre by the presence of 15,000 Lebanese soldiers and 13,000 belonging to UNIFIL, whose means and mandate were reinforced by Resolution 1701, pursuant to which Hizbollah significantly redeployed from the border area to north of the Litani River.

Moreover, Hizbollah realises that the state of inter-sectarian relations means Shiites risk not having a safe haven in the event of renewed confrontation. Nor are Shiites hungry for more fighting. Crisis Group heard numerous complaints from southern residents who, while supporting Hizbollah's armed status as deterrence, criticised its single-minded focus on resistance, aspirations to a regional role and inadequate efforts to help civilians.¹¹⁴ Short of alienating and endangering its own constituency, Hizbollah will find it hard to take unprovoked military action in the South. For now, it has halted the attacks – known as "reminder operations" (*'amaliyat tazkiriya*) – it periodically undertook in the Shebaa Farms.¹¹⁵

Hizbollah is adapting in several ways. The shift from resistance to deterrence – a trend that began with the 2000 withdrawal – has become more pronounced, with much day-to-day activity concentrating on commemorations of past exploits.¹¹⁶ The thickened security presence in the

that UN forces can travel unimpeded in their area of deployment, including former Hizbollah bunkers. Crisis Group interview, South Lebanon, July 2007. For Nicholas Blanford, a well-informed Hizbollah watcher, "the conflict forced the Islamic Resistance to expose six years of military preparations, including the underground network of bunkers and firing positions which were far more elaborate than previously thought". "Hizbollah prepares for war", *Jane's Defence Weekly*, 11 April 2007.

¹¹⁴ Crisis Group interviews, South Lebanon, May 2007. According to Timor Goksel, Hizbollah cannot afford another confrontation at this time because "even its own social base would not accept it, given how much it suffered last time around". Crisis Group interview, 3 February 2007.

¹¹⁵ Hizbollah claims these will resume "once the international community will have failed to liberate the farms". Nabil Qawuq, quoted in Amal Saad-Ghorayeb, "In their own words: Hizbollah's strategy in the current confrontation", *Policy Outlook*, Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, January 2007, p. 13.

¹¹⁶ These include, inter alia, ceremonies marking Israel's 2000 withdrawal; *ashura* (commemorating Imam Hussein's martyrdom); the anniversary of the death of two prominent Hizbollah leaders, Abbas al-Musawi and Raghib Harb; the "week of Islamic resistance"; the "day of the martyr"; the "week of Islamic unity"; the festival in support of the resistance; Jerusalem Day; the day of the wounded; the anniversary of Imam Khomeini's death; and the festival of the "divine victory". In the wake of the war, the movement also produced much memorabilia, poetry, songs and CDs glorifying its militants. In August 2007, it inaugurated an open-air museum in southern Beirut giving its version of the 2006 war and seeking to debunk the notion of Israel's invincibility. It is called the "Spider's House" – the term used by Nasrallah to describe Israel's army as outwardly solid yet inherently fragile.

South is a barrier that hinders but also can protect. A pro-Hizbollah sheikh there described UNIFIL as integral to the movement's defensive strategy. "Of course, publicly Hizbollah says that UNIFIL serves Israel's interests. But we have extensive contacts with UNIFIL, and we trust its local leaders. We know its presence makes any Israeli attack that much more difficult and, in the event of a war, it is inconceivable that UNIFIL will attack the Resistance"¹¹⁷ The view is echoed by Timor Goksel, the former UNIFIL spokesman: "UNIFIL and the Lebanese army in the South are now considered as defensive lines".¹¹⁸

The presence of UN forces also has led Hizbollah to strengthen its position around its second line of defence, north of the Litani River, in the East and in the Bekaa.¹¹⁹ A knowledgeable Hizbollah watcher said:

On the ground, Hizbollah is establishing a new line of defence just north of the Litani River, which marks the northern limit of UNIFIL's area of operations. The Islamic Resistance has expanded and increased the number of positions in the mountains between the Litani River and Kfar Houne village, sealing off valleys and hill-tops to outsiders. New weapons storage facilities are being constructed in the southern Bekaa Valley and in the area around Nabatieh. Training has intensified at the dozens of camps located in Shia-populated areas along the eastern and western flanks of the Bekaa Valley.¹²⁰

Nasrallah's 3 August 2007 speech, in which he paid particular tribute to the people of the Bekaa, should be understood in this context. "The region of Baalback Hermel in particular and of the Bekaa more generally is not a rearguard base. It is a front line just like the regions south and north of the Litani River".¹²¹

Among other lessons Hizbollah learned from the war is the need both to blunt Israel's air supremacy (manifested through aerial surveillance, unmanned drones and other means of detecting ground movement) and to augment the number of armed militants to resist any land incursion. Hizbollah reportedly acquired more sophisticated Russian and Chinese made anti-aircraft material and dispatched

personnel to Iran for training.¹²² At the same time, it is recruiting fighters to help its elite, professional militants, including among non-Shiites who backed it during the war.¹²³ Mahmud Qumati evokes "not hundreds but thousands" of new recruits who are being trained, chiefly Shiite, but also Druze, Sunnis, and Christians.¹²⁴ The purpose of such recruiting and training remains highly contentious. Hizbollah argues that the goal is to expand the resistance to "non-religious" militants.¹²⁵ Its opponents, however, are convinced it has nothing to do with the struggle against Israel but rather is being undertaken in anticipation of a civil war. They point in particular to the fact that Aounists, as well as followers of Wi'am Wahhab (a Druze) and of Usama Saad (a Sunni) are being armed and trained, and "it is hard to convince many Lebanese that this is being done with an eye to fighting Israel".¹²⁶

All that said, the closing of the southern front carries major implications for Hizbollah. In particular, it means that the movement must pursue goals chiefly by focusing on Lebanon's domestic politics.

B. FOCUS ON DOMESTIC POLITICS

Discussions concerning the movement's future often revolve around whether it eventually will become a party like any other, taking part in Lebanon's political game and abdicating its armed status. Some believe the process of accommodation is in train, pointing to its decision to participate in parliamentary elections in the early 1990s and in the government in 2005. Its more recent call for a national

¹²² See *Al-Siyasa*, a Kuwaiti daily often critical of Syria, 18 April 2007. According to the report, a first batch of approximately 500 militants was sent to Iran and completed training on 16 April. They have since allegedly returned to Lebanon via Damascus airport.

¹²³ A similar attempt to set up battalions supervised by – albeit not belonging to – Hizbollah, known as *Saraya al-Muqawama* (Resistance Battalions), was made in the late 1990s. It failed for several reasons, including opposition from Damascus (allegedly fear that weapons provided to Sunnis could be turned against them. Crisis Group interview, Abu Ali, former military leader of the Murabitun, a Nasserite armed movement, Beirut 28 April 2007), and the feeling among non-Shiites that they were being treated like second-class fighters.

¹²⁴ Crisis Group interview, Mahmud Qumati, vice president of Hizbollah's political council, Beirut, 19 September 2007.

¹²⁵ Ibid. Amin Hotait, a military expert, argues this also is a way for Hizbollah to attract Amal militants who are disappointed in their party. Crisis Group phone interview, Amin Hoteit, former army general with close ties to the opposition, Beirut, 22 September 2007.

¹²⁶ Crisis Group email communication, Lebanese analyst, October 2007. The arming of militias has extended to many other groups, Christian in particular, and is a major source of worry. See *The New York Times*, 6 October 2007.

¹¹⁷ Crisis Group interview, Saad Allah Khalil, Qulaili, South Lebanon, 27 April 2007.

¹¹⁸ Crisis Group interview, Timor Goksel, Beirut, 16 August 2007.

¹¹⁹ This does not mean that the movement has abandoned the South; Hizbollah sympathisers and militants abound, many are armed and, according to a UNIFIL officer, light weapons are present in urban areas in anticipation of possible warfare, Crisis Group interview, South Lebanon, July 2007; Crisis Group interview, Timor Goksel, Beirut, 16 August 2007.

¹²⁰ Blanford, op. cit.

¹²¹ *Al-Manar*, 3 August 2007.

unity government also could be viewed as a step in gradual “Lebanisation”.

The presumed dichotomy between politics and resistance is misconceived. Far from being a substitute for armed resistance, Hizbollah’s political involvement has become its necessary corollary. Given rapidly shifting internal and external landscapes, the Shiite movement calculates that deeper political engagement is the best way to safeguard its armed status.¹²⁷ As the vice president of Hizbollah’s research centre put it, “paradoxically, some want us to get involved in the political process in order to neutralise us. In fact, we intend to get involved – but precisely in order to protect the strategic choice of resistance and political participation”.¹²⁸ Resistance is and remains Hizbollah’s priority, its *raison d’être*, a means of liberating Lebanese land, unifying Arab and Muslim ranks, protecting Lebanon from attempts to reshape its political identity in a more pro-Western direction¹²⁹ but also, increasingly, of thwarting Washington’s perceived attempts to dominate the region. In this struggle against a U.S.-led regional order, Hizbollah relies on support from Iran, Syria and others in forming an axis of refusal (*jabhat al-mumana’a*).

1. Safeguarding the resistance

Unlike Amal, Hizbollah does not view politics as an end in itself and has not made Shiite representation its priority. For an expert on the movement, “Hizbollah has only two priorities: the Palestinian question and resistance against U.S. regional projects. All other objectives, including Shiite empowerment, are ancillary”.¹³⁰ Likewise, a sheikh sympathetic to Hizbollah said, “What matters to Hizbollah is its culture of resistance. Hizbollah never advocated a strong presence on the local political scene other than in order to allocate services at the municipal level. That’s why Hizbollah parliamentary members rarely are the people the movement truly values”.¹³¹

It follows that the movement’s relation to the central state has always been assessed in terms of its impact on the resistance. At the outset, it steered clear of direct participation in the domestic political game, believing it would be corrupted, dragged into confessional, patron-client relations and forfeit its special status. It evolved gradually and always conceived of politics as an essentially negative activity, designed not so much to promote a specific agenda as to

block hostile ones. Through various steps, it adjusted to Lebanon’s shifting political situation with an eye toward safeguarding its weapons and special status. Thus, in the wake of the 1989 Taef Accords, which among other items called for the disbanding of armed militias, Hizbollah participated in the 1992 legislative elections in order to protect its weapons,¹³² calling its ensuing parliamentary group the “bloc of loyalty to the Resistance” – the name it continues to carry to this day.

In 2005, following Syria’s military withdrawal and passage of Resolution 1559 which, again, called for the dismantling of all militias, the movement for the first time agreed to enter the government. Nawaf al-Musawi, in charge of Hizbollah’s external relations, commented at the time that “Syria’s withdrawal from Lebanon created a vacuum in the country’s political scene . . . and international powers are trying to take advantage of this vacuum and impose their tutelage over Lebanon”.¹³³ The view was echoed by Ali Fayyad, head of Hizbollah’s think tank:

During two decades of resistance, Hizbollah approached political authority with militant puritanism, which not only excluded seeking power but also led it to consider access to power as contradicting the rationale and requirements of the resistance. What compelled Hizbollah to take the dramatic step of joining the government was the profound transformations in the Lebanese political balance after the withdrawal of the Syrian troops. Syria’s withdrawal . . . alter[ed] the relative size of the various forces, reveal[ed] some of the key choices in State policies and expos[ed] Lebanon’s vulnerable position in the regional equation.¹³⁴

As a member of the cabinet, Hizbollah insisted the government’s program endorse the right of resistance.¹³⁵

The post-July 2006 war demand for a national unity government in which the current opposition would hold a blocking minority stems from a similar rationale. It was Hizbollah’s response to criticism of its unilateral military action and pressure to disarm coupled with an attempt to halt what it perceived as the government’s slide toward an increasingly pro-American and pro-Saudi stance.¹³⁶

¹²⁷ Crisis Group interview, Mahmud Qumati, vice president of Hizbollah’s political council, Beirut, 11 October 2006.

¹²⁸ Crisis Group interview, Abdel Halim Fadlallah, Beirut, 27 April 2007.

¹²⁹ Crisis Group interview, Qasem Qasir, journalist and Hizbollah expert, Beirut, 7 March 2007.

¹³⁰ Crisis Group interview, Walid Charara, Beirut, 29 May 2007.

¹³¹ Crisis Group interview, pro-Hizbollah sheikh, South Lebanon, 23 April 2007.

¹³² Crisis Group interview, Nabil Qawuq, Hizbollah official responsible for the South, Tyr, 11 October 2006.

¹³³ *Daily Star*, 18 June 2005.

¹³⁴ Ali Fayyad, “Hizbollah and the Lebanese state: reconciling a national strategy with a regional role”, *Arab Reform Initiative*, August 2006.

¹³⁵ For the full text of the ministerial declaration, see *Diary of the Israeli War on Lebanon* (Beirut, 2006), p. 324. The book is the collective work of journalists from the *Safir* newspaper.

¹³⁶ “Immediately after the war, the issue of our weapons and of the resistance were publicly debated. For a short time afterwards, things quieted down. Yet, under U.S. pressure, the March 14

Justifying its call, Hizbollah said it was warranted by its military victory¹³⁷ and that it aspired to be in a position to impede any decision that threatened the resistance and its strategic interests. Nabil Qawuq, the movement's leader in the South, stated:

During the war, we were ready to accept anything to ensure Lebanon was united in its struggle against Israel. Then, in the war's immediate aftermath, we hoped that our political opponents would pull themselves together and take stock of the new situation. And yet, when the war ended, they continued to attack us politically. We decided we had to put it to an end. And for that, we needed a national unity government that could guarantee and protect what the resistance had attained.¹³⁸

As Hizbollah sees it, the political crisis is the war's continuation by other means. Nasrallah put it plainly: "What has happened since the end of the war is an extension of Israel's war against Lebanon. And just as we fought in July and August, so we will fight today but with other weapons and other rules".¹³⁹ Nawaf al-Musawi claims "the government is striving to execute what Israel failed to do".¹⁴⁰ In other words, the principal goal is not to ensure more equitable participation – though Hizbollah argued that Aoun's camp deserved better representation – but to protect the movement's weapons. Qumati put it as follows: "Political participation is not what matters to us. We are doing this to save the country. It is the way to defend ourselves against any decision that might threaten the resistance or affect Lebanon's fundamental strategic and political choices".¹⁴¹

Symptomatically, Hizbollah is not asking that ministers come from its ranks but rather from the ranks of its allies.

forces have brought the matter back to the fore". Crisis Group interview, Abdel Hamid Fadlallah, vice president of Hizbollah's research centre, Beirut, 27 April 2007.

¹³⁷ At an October 2006 rally, Hashem Safi Eddine, Nasrallah's cousin and a prominent member of Hizbollah's leading political body, the *Majlis al-Shura*, explained: "When someone wins a war, he can ask for anything. All we ask for is to enlarge the government for the sake of national unity", Jerusalem Day rally attended by Crisis Group, Nabatiyeh, 20 October 2006.

¹³⁸ Crisis Group interview, Nabil Qawuq, Tyr, 17 October 2006. Nasrallah said the same, arguing that the March 14 forces "want to remain in power, which has become a real problem because they do not want power for the sake of power but rather because they made a number of political and economic commitments and promises. If we have a blocking third (*thulth muatal*), they will not be able to carry them out". Interview with Al Jazeera, 12 September 2006.

¹³⁹ Interview on *al-Manar* television, 16 February 2006.

¹⁴⁰ Amal Saad-Ghorayeb, "In their own words", op. cit., p. 6.

¹⁴¹ Crisis Group interview, Mahmud Qumati, Beirut, 3 February 2006.

thereby allowing it to both control the government indirectly and maintain some distance from it. Nor have Hizbollah's leaders offered any clarity as to how they would wish to alter the government's policies, other than a vague rejection of U.S. influence.¹⁴² At the local level, involvement in politics has come at a cost – indeed, precisely the cost that had kept Hizbollah away in the first place. It has forged alliances with odd bedfellows and engaged in clientelist political practices.¹⁴³ For Antoine Alouf, a Christian elected on Hizbollah's list in Baalbek, "the conversion of a militant and disciplined movement, adept at allocating services within its own institutions to a political movement that serves citizens through local institutions has proved difficult".¹⁴⁴ For others, Hizbollah's appeal as a resistance movement coexists with criticism of its local management.¹⁴⁵

More broadly, if it wishes to preserve its image as a different kind of political movement, Hizbollah will need to implement a genuinely reformist, state-building agenda. That is a tall order unlikely to be met since it would mean alienating virtually all actors currently controlling the Lebanese system. More importantly, it would seriously undercut the party's two core assets: resistance (insofar as an independent armed force is incompatible with the building of a strong central state), and its cliental relationship with the Shiite community (insofar as a truly reformed state would do away with or at least mitigate such loyalties).

2. Containing U.S. influence

In July 2003 Crisis Group noted that Israel's 2000 withdrawal, by drying up one of the principal justifications for the resistance, had "created [Hizbollah's] first true strategic dilemma".¹⁴⁶ Although occupation of the Shebaa Farms, Israel's detention of Lebanese prisoners and continued Israeli infringement of Lebanese sovereignty resonated, they were far less effective at mobilising national support for armed resistance. Crisis Group suggested the movement increasingly was turning to "the struggle between Islamism and Arab nationalism on the one hand, and U.S. and Israeli domination on the other" as the rationale for its continued existence as an armed resistance group.¹⁴⁷

¹⁴² According to Ali Fayyad, the movement has drafted a plan for institutional reforms but will await resolution of the political crisis before publishing it. Crisis Group interview, Beirut, 30 May 2007.

¹⁴³ Crisis Group interviews, local politicians allied to Hizbollah, Hizbollah experts, Beirut, Bekaa, April-July 2007.

¹⁴⁴ Crisis Group interview, Antoine Alouf, Baalbek, 23 April 2007.

¹⁴⁵ Crisis Group interviews, tribal leaders, al-Nabi Shiit, Bekaa Valley; local politician, Baalbek, April 2007.

¹⁴⁶ Crisis Group Briefing, *Rebel Without a Cause*, op. cit., p. 7.

¹⁴⁷ Ibid, p. 18.

Clearly that is now the case. Since the 2006 war, Hizbollah has concluded that the paramount conflict is with the U.S. and the central goal is to thwart its efforts to reshape the Middle East. The U.S. in this view is less Israel's instrument than Israel is America's. A political council member said, "we do not want to belong to America's sphere of influence. We want ours to be a sphere of resistance to America's project".¹⁴⁸ *Muqawama* (resistance) against Israel is now complemented – some would say superseded – by *mumana'a* (refusal) of U.S. military, political, economic and cultural influence. In this, Hizbollah's allies are Iran, Hamas and Syria.

For Hizbollah, therefore, Lebanon's identity and attitude towards neighbours and international actors is at stake in the current domestic tug-of-war. Hence its insistence on increasing the movement's political influence and being in a position to obstruct decisions inconsistent with its world view (whether relating to armed status, the configuration of national armed forces or relations with the West, Israel or Syria).

III. HIZBOLLAH'S ISLAMIC IDENTITY

Hizbollah's focus on the political scene and demands for a greater voice have renewed fears regarding its domestic intentions. One concern in particular is that the movement will sooner or later revert to its primordial Islamic identity and seek to impose Islamic rule.

The fear is not unfounded. Despite claims that the ultimate goal is now social justice rather than religious governance, Hizbollah has yet to amend its founding document, the 1985 "Open Letter", which calls, inter alia, for establishment of an Islamic state and presents the party as an "Islamist Jihadist movement".¹⁴⁹ Although it concedes that this can only be a result of the people's free choice, several aspects of its behaviour are cause for disquiet. Hizbollah's culture is profoundly religious, and its relationship with the nation-state remains ambiguous. Its name and origins – as an outgrowth of the Iranian revolution – aside, the movement continues to display several Islamist characteristics. Insofar as it embraces the principle of *wilayat al-faqih*,¹⁵⁰ acceptance of which is a precondition for joining the party, it acknowledges the authority of Iran's Supreme Leader at both the political and religious levels.

By the same token, the party continues to be essentially led by clerics who also play a key role in the political and religious education of the rank-and-file. Militants are

¹⁴⁹ For an analysis of the Open Letter, see Joseph Alagha, *The Shifts in Hizbullah's Ideology: Religious Ideology, Political Ideology, and Political Program* (Beirut, 2006), pp. 36-37. Despite claims it is already written, Hizbollah does not seem to be in a hurry to publish the new document, Crisis Group interviews, Hizbollah political leaders, Beirut, September 2007.

¹⁵⁰ The 1985 Open Letter says, "we address all the Arab and Islamic peoples to declare to them that the Muslim's experience in Islamic Iran left no one any excuse since it proved beyond all doubt that bare chests motivated by faith are capable, with God's help, of breaking the iron and oppression of tyrannical regimes", quoted and translated in Norton, op. cit., p. 36. Hizbollah adheres to the Iranian revolution's principle of *wilayat al-faqih* (rule of the jurispudent, which subjects the government to both the religious scholar's supreme authority and Islamic law (Sharia)) and follows the guidance of Iran's Supreme Leader. Naem Qasem, Hizbollah's deputy secretary general, describes in detail the Supreme Leader's authority over the movement, including his religious and worldly authority, giving him decision-making power on questions of war and peace, *Hizbollah, The Method, the Experience, the Future* (Beirut, 2004), pp. 74-78 (in Arabic). For a fuller explanation of the concept of *wilayat al-faqih* (*velayat-e fakih* in Farsi, as the concept is known in Iran), see Crisis Group Middle East and North Africa Report N°37, *Understanding Islamism*, 2 March 2005, pp. 22-23; also Middle East Report N°5, *Iran: The Struggle for the Revolution's Soul*, 5 August 2002, and Middle East Report N°55, *Iraq's Muqtada Al-Sadr: Spoiler or Stabiliser?*, 11 July 2006.

¹⁴⁸ Crisis Group interview, Ghalib Abu Zeinab, Beirut, 13 September 2006.